

With every passing year, the performance and capacity bar of digital storage technologies has been raised. This is good news for computer users, as the need for larger and faster storage solutions is imperative, considering how resource-hungry today's applications and operating systems have become. Usage patterns have also changed rapidly, and the home PC is now increasingly used for data-intensive tasks, such as ripping entire Audio CD collections to MP3 files and making VCDs of special occasions to share with loved ones.

The digital age has brought with it the need to store vast amounts of data, which has in turn created a market that witnesses the spawning of bigger and faster storage devices with amazing regularity.

Of course, all of this would mean little if the devices in question weren't affordable. The good news is that thanks to a very competitive market and demanding consumers, the storage subsystem has kept pace with the bandwidth demands of today's applications, and 7200 rpm hard disk drives with a minimum storage space of 40 GB and above are now more common than ever before.

Market Conditions

The demand for storage in PCs has

boomed. With a lot of multimedia files being used today, including MP3, Flash files and movies—even today's entry-level 40 GB hard disks aren't enough for users. The cost of a 40 GB hard disk ranges from Rs 4,300 to Rs 4,500.

On the other hand, 60 to 80 GB, 7200 rpm drives are also available and are preferred by professionals. These are available for Rs 8,500 to Rs 9,000. Seeing the demand for higher capacity drives, Maxtor recently launched its 250 GB hard disk in the IDE interface for around Rs. 16,000. With Serial ATA hard disk technology knocking at the door, users might once again see an upheaval in the coming months. This technology, although its infant stage would really push the existing ATA 100/133 to its end due to the sheer fact of ease of use and low power consumption as compared to the existing drives. As it uses a much smaller interface connector and cable, the space inside the cabinet increases and provides for more efficient cooling.

Today some of the drives available are as fast as 15000 rpm which are extremely good for multimedia applications such as ripping of movies and MP3 songs. Due to the speed, these drives generate a lot of heat and thus need special cooling, for which vendors, such as Antec have launched special hard disk cooling devices that bring down the temperature of the disk by around 10 to 15 degrees—this enhances the performance as well as the life of the disk. Although not popular yet, it has many followers with users looking for performance.



Buying tips for Hard Disks

- Speed or space? If you need to store MP3s and DivX films, or to back up heavy image files, buy the largest hard disk you can afford. On the other hand, if you extensively use applications such as image editing or audio processing software, look for the fastest hard disk you can afford—at least a 7200 rpm drive - and buy the largest in that speed range.
- Research the market. Ask your friends or dealers you know, or search the Internet for information about the manufacturer, the reputation they enjoy and their after-sales service.
- Check the warranty. Apart from the time frame covered, also check the type

of warranty. Some manufacturers will replace the hard disk only in the first year, after which they will only repair it. This is rather unreliable and can lead to more problems in the future.

■ Confirm the time it takes to replace a faulty hard disk. This is especially important if your business relies heavily on data storage. Generally, manufacturers who run a service centre are able to provide quick replacements, while those who don't have service centres could take weeks to replace a faulty hard disk.

■ Check for accessories such as IDE cables, disk management software and operating manuals.

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